



Contents lists available at ScienceDirect

Journal of Business Research

journal homepage: www.elsevier.com/locate/jbusres

Influencer advertising on social media: The multiple inference model on influencer-product congruence and sponsorship disclosure

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ARTICLE INFO

Keywords:

Influencer advertising
Native advertising
Multiple motive inference
Influencer-product congruence
Sponsorship disclosure
Advertising recognition

ABSTRACT

This study investigates the effects of influencer advertising attributes on consumer responses via multiple motive inference processing. Influencer-product congruence and sponsorship disclosure are manipulated as independent variables. In so doing, this study examines whether social media users infer two types of motives (Affective vs. Calculative) of the influencer derived from perceived congruence (High vs. Low) and sponsorship disclosure (Presence vs. Absence). Results suggest that influencer-product congruence can be used to enhance product attitude and reduce advertising recognition by generating a higher affective motive inference. Sponsorship disclosure can also affect product attitude in a serial mediation of calculative motive inference and advertising recognition. The multiple motive inference model explained the dual processing of influencer advertising by attributing to the prior persuasion knowledge and situational characteristics simultaneously. The findings discussed theoretical and managerial implications on native advertising on social media.

1. Introduction

Social media has fundamentally changed the way people interact and communicate, offering a greater capability for marketers to connect with their target customers. In recent years, influencer marketing (i.e., contents paid for by brands but posted by influencers) has expanded rapidly on social media (Wijesinghe, 2017). The influencer marketing industry is estimated to reach \$2.3 billion in 2020 from \$0.5 million in 2015 (Mediakix, 2018). Influencers tend to post regularly on their preferred social media platforms and generate a large volume of engaged followers who pay close attention to their opinions. Through influencer advertising, marketers reach their target audience effectively and deliver a message through a trusted source (Brown & Hayes, 2008). Furthermore, influencers are attaining high responsiveness from social media users while typical marketing messages are struggling with consumer avoidance and negligence. In a consumer survey, 92% of social media users reported they trust influencers over traditional marketing media and 74% of “digital natives” resist being targeted by brand pages on social media (Eyal, 2018a). Therefore, research is needed to unravel the process of how influencers can persuade social media users successfully.

Influencers deliver marketing messages in a format of native advertising. Specifically, native advertising is defined as “a form of paid content marketing, where the commercial content adopts the form and

function of editorial content and is delivered with an attempt to recreate the user experience of reading news instead of advertising content.” (Conill, 2016, p. 2). As influencers promote products in their personal editorial contents, consumers do not always recognize their commercial intent. Influencers’ postings are typically based on their everyday lives, which appear to be more natural and genuine (Lueck, 2015). In addition, the payment or the sponsorship is not always evident. Therefore, influencers’ commercial postings may not be discernible from non-commercial postings (Shrum, 2012). For instance, more than half of the social media users are not aware that celebrities are promoting products in their social media postings (Langford & Baldwin, 2013).

Consequently, practical sanctions are imposed to enhance advertising transparency and prevent the deceptiveness of influencer advertising. In 2017, the Federal Trade Commission (FTC) issued warnings to many social media influencers for failure to clearly disclose their relationships with brands and products they promote (Nesbitt, 2017). Furthermore, the UK’s Advertising Standards Authority also set a new guideline to ensure the clarity and honesty in influencers’ communication by disclosing commercial relationships they may have with brands (Arnold, 2018). Followed by the sanctions, the number of influencer contents openly indicating the nature of sponsorship has substantially increased by 200% between 2018 and 2019 (Businesswire, 2019). Social media users also acknowledge the nature of influencer

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Received 26 November 2018; Received in revised form 7 February 2020; Accepted 8 February 2020

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advertising more than ever before (Knutson, 2019). Thus, it is critical for marketers to understand how sponsorship disclosure is interpreted by social media users and impacts advertising outcomes.

Previous studies explored the processing of a sponsorship message in the native advertising context (e.g., Boerman, Willemsen, & Van Der Aa, 2017; Campbell & Evans, 2018; Evans, Phua, Lim, & Jun, 2017; Evans, Wojdyski, & Grubbs Hoy, 2019; Wojdyski, Evans, & Hoy, 2018). The findings demonstrated that sponsorship disclosure on a social media posting is processed as persuasion knowledge (Friestad & Wright, 1994). In other words, the sponsorship message makes social media users recognize the posting as advertising and process it as persuasion knowledge. As a result, it negatively affects consumer responses including brand attitude, purchase intention, and eWOM (Boerman et al., 2017; Evans et al., 2017).

Despite the negative impact of sponsorship disclosure, influencers can still appeal to consumers by their natural match to an endorsed commercial entity. They can take advantage of their personal editorial content to justify their endorsement. Specifically, they can promote a commercial entity by providing a reasonable relation to their identity and making it a plausible extension of their preexisting organic contents. Recent research suggests that congruence between the influencer and the commercial entity is critical to the acceptance of native advertising (Breves, Liebers, Abt, & Kunze, 2019; Kim, Lee, & Chung, 2017; Schouten, Janssen, & Verspaget, 2019). For instance, influencers' match to the entity is a positive element for successful native advertising by naturalizing the marketing message (Kim et al., 2017). Recent research further supports that: (a) the influencer-brand fit affects persuasion enhancing the source credibility (Breves et al., 2019); and (b) the influencer-product fit moderates the effect of endorser type on trustworthiness and expertise (Schouten et al., 2019). In sum, congruence probes the association between the influencer and the consumption object (e.g., brand, product) and strengthens the persuasion effectiveness of the message.

This study builds on the notion that social media users consider sponsorship disclosure as well as the influencer-product congruence collectively when evaluating influencer advertising. There is little research examining the dual processing of sponsorship disclosure and influencer-product congruence, thus, it is unclear how social media users decide to accept an influencer message while being aware of the sponsorship behind it. Previous studies on influencer advertising were limited to testing either sponsorship or congruence effects separately (Breves et al., 2019; Evans et al., 2017; Evans et al., 2019; Schouten et al., 2019; Wojdyski et al., 2018). To address this research gap, this research further investigates the influencer advertising processing based on the model of multiple motive inferences (Reeder, Vonk, Ronk, Ham, & Lawrence, 2004; Reeder, 2009). Specifically, the multiple inference model posits that individuals consider their preexisting knowledge in addition to situation characteristics to interpret the target (Reeder, 2009). As native advertising delivers a marketing message via personal contents, the prior knowledge on commercial intention coexists with the organic format. Therefore, the dual aspects of influencer advertising can be explained by the processing of multiple motive inferences.

In sum, this study investigates that influencer-product congruence and sponsorship disclosure can be processed by affective and calculative motive inferences on the influencer's content from the social media user perspective through study 1 and study 2. First, this study examines whether influencer-product congruence and sponsorship disclosure affect product attitude and advertising recognition as native advertising. Second, the interpretation of those attributes by social media users will be proposed by the mediation of multiple motive inferences. Finally, how the negative effect of sponsorship disclosure is moderated by congruence will be tested.

2. Literature review and hypothesis development

2.1. Native advertising on social Media: Influencer advertising

Influencers assist marketing activities by affecting the potential consumer group of a brand or product (Brown & Hayes, 2008). According to the Interactive Advertising Bureau (2018), social media influencers are defined as those who "have the potential to create engagement, drive conversation, and/or sell products/services with the intended target audience; these individuals can range from celebrities to more micro-targeted professional or nonprofessional peers." Influencers include celebrities, brand community members, bloggers, and experts specialized in specific topics (Jin & Phua, 2014; Kim, Sung, & Kang, 2014; Lee & Watkins, 2016). They share contents on social media and often post their experience in the events hosted by a brand to promote the brand or its products. They also work as spokespersons by endorsing the product, and increasing brand awareness and consumer engagement (Nordqvist, 2018). The relationship duration with followers, the relative share of posts, and network size are significant influencer qualities that create a larger effect on marketing communication (Chatterjee, 2011). In addition, credibility, expertise, enthusiasm, and connectivity to influence people are also desirable to become a successful influencer (Bakshy, Hofman, Mason, & Watts, 2011).

Influencers perform marketing activities through native advertising, which originally referred to paid advertisements in the editorial content of a publisher (Evans et al., 2017). Native advertising can confuse consumers about a communication source and the payment nature by blurring the editorial-commercial content boundary (Conill, 2016). Specifically, influencers promote brands or products through their organic personal experience content. Thereby, the audience can be persuaded by influencers' content, which they would have avoided had they realized it was advertising (Boerman et al., 2017).

In sum, influencers can successfully accomplish marketing activities by introducing the product as an organic versus commercial content. Social media users are more likely to be receptive to a promotional message when it is considered as a genuine message of the influencer. Thus, this study focuses on the significant attributes of influencer advertising for being successfully processed as native advertising.

2.2. Perceived congruence

Congruence refers to the degree of similarity between two objects or activities (Olson & Thjomø, 2011). The congruity principle asserts that congruent information is recalled and preferred over incongruent information (Osgood & Tannenbaum, 1955). Specifically, congruence can establish a stronger associative link and further generate greater memory spreading activation and higher accessibility of attitude (Till & Busler, 2000; Zdravkovic & Till, 2012). In celebrity endorsements or advertising, congruence is applied to assess the fit between the spokesperson and the endorsed entity (Kamins & Gupta, 1994; Till & Busler, 2000). The congruence in a celebrity endorsement results from the consistency between the relevant spokesperson characteristics and relevant entity attributes (Misra & Beatty, 1990). In other words, a spokesperson whose characteristics are highly coherent to the entity can create a high level of association.

Congruence is crucial to celebrity endorsement or advertising effectiveness (Hunt, 1998). Successful celebrity-endorsed product association enhances the advertisement and product evaluation (Fleck, Korchia, & Le Roy, 2012; Till & Busler, 2000). This is explained by the match-up hypothesis in which the message conveyed by the highly matched celebrity can result in a greater accessibility and a positive effect on attitude (Baker & Churchill, 1977; Kamins, 1990). The congruence effect is also valid for sponsorship. Sponsorship to a highly relevant event can generate a higher associative link and further enhances the attitude to the sponsor (Ellen, Mohr, & Webb, 2000; Rifon, Choi, Trimble, & Li, 2004; Rodgers, 2003; Speed & Thompson, 2000).

and consumer purchase behavior (Cornwell, Pruitt, & Van Ness, 2001).

In native advertising, congruence is critical to consumer responses as it intends to be perceived as personal editorial content rather than purposeful marketing. If native advertising is perceived to be consistent with the editorial environment and assumed to be organic content, it can reduce the Internet users' resistance (Cramer, 2015). For instance, prior research suggests that native advertising that is contextually matched (vs. less matched) with a social media platform results in a greater positive effect on the advertising and product evaluation (Kim et al., 2017). Extending this research stream, this study postulates that consumer responses will be positively affected when an influencer posts a particular product congruent with his/her specialty. Thus, perceived congruence will positively affect the product attitude and negatively affect advertising recognition.

H1. High influencer-product congruence in influencer advertising will have a) a positive effect on product attitude and b) a negative effect on advertising recognition.

2.3. Disclosure of sponsorship message

According to the persuasion knowledge model (PKM), individuals learn to understand and become aware of the persuasive intent in marketing messages through experience (Friestad & Wright, 1994). Persuasion knowledge refers to “the knowledge that enables them to recognize, analyze, interpret, evaluate, and remember persuasion attempts, and select and execute coping tactics believed to be effective and appropriate” (Friestad & Wright, 1994, p. 3). Disclosing a sponsorship message also relates to the persuasion knowledge, and results in defensive responses from the recipient. In a study on online information search, information from the organic link was chosen by 77% of respondents, which was larger than that of the sponsored link (Hotchkiss, Garrison, & Jensen, 2004). In addition, the sponsored link content was evaluated to be of lower quality than the organic link, as online users were explicitly suspicious about sponsored links (Jansen & Resnick, 2006). In native advertising, sponsorship disclosure is the critical persuasion knowledge to social media users. When the native advertising attempts to deliver a message in a personal editorial content, the sponsorship message indicates an external source of interest and compensation. Furthermore, advertising recognition can trigger behavioral reactance to the marketing communication. According to the reactance theory (Brehm, 1989), individuals are likely to resist persuasion attempts when they recognize them (Williams, Fitzsimons, & Block, 2004) and engage in coping strategies such as skepticism and resistance. When social media users recognize the situation as being targeted by a marketing communication, they can engage in a reactance mechanism and counterargue the message. In previous studies on native advertising, persuasion knowledge including advertising recognition resulted in a reactance to the sponsored messages and negative brand attitude (Boerman, Van Reijmersdal, & Neijens, 2015; Evans et al., 2017; Van Reijmersdal et al., 2016; Wojdyski & Evans, 2016). Specifically, Boerman et al. (2017) examined the sponsorship disclosure effect on the perception of conceptual persuasion knowledge. Their findings suggested that sponsorship disclosure generates advertising recognition and causes distrust about a social media posting. If an influencer posting reveals the sponsorship, social media users can recognize it as advertising and develop less favorable product attitude.

H2. The sponsorship disclosure in influencer advertising will have (a) a negative effect on product attitude and (b) a positive effect on advertising recognition

H3. The advertising recognition will negatively affect product attitude.

2.4. Multiple inference model: affective and calculative motive inference

People often engage in inference processing to understand the underlying motives of an observed behavior. Inference refers to the meaning formed based on available information (Dick, Chakravarti, & Biehal, 1990). The Multiple Inference Model (MIM) has been applied to understand how people perceive others' behavior by inferring several motives behind it (Reeder et al., 2004; Reeder, 2009). This model suggests that individuals can attribute a single behavior to multiple alternative motives depending on the behavioral intention and the nature of situation (Verlegh, Ryu, Tuk, & Feick, 2013). Specifically, affective and calculative motive inferences were suggested to explain the responses to sponsorship marketing (Woisetschlager, Backhaus, & Cornwell, 2017). The affective motive inference attributes sponsorship to the affectionate intention toward the sponsored property out of free choice. Furthermore, calculative motive inference assumes an ulterior motive of marketing communication behind sponsorship. When multiple motive inferences were examined for sports event sponsorship, perceived sponsor-property congruence was positively associated with the affective motives and the attitude towards the sponsor, but negatively associated with the calculative motives (Woisetschlager et al., 2017). When people perceive a sponsorship to be out of an emotional attachment—an affective motive inference—it results in a more favorable attitude towards the sponsor. However, people formulate a negative attitude if they suspect an ulterior motive behind the sponsorship—a calculative motive inference.

As native advertising obfuscates the commercial intent and the payment with its editorial content, viewers can make multiple inferences about the influencer's motives. Extending the MIM to influencer advertising, this study examines the affective and calculative motive inferences. Specifically, when the product is relevant and expected from the influencer, social media users may assume that posting reflects the influencer's genuine emotion for the product. In doing so, the influencer-product congruence will evoke high affective motive inference among social media users. On the other hand, a sponsorship message in influencer advertising will function as persuasion knowledge and become the inferential cue of high calculative motives. In other words, when a sponsorship message is disclosed, social media users are likely to infer that the sponsorship's compensation may be the reason why the influencer promotes the product. Thereby, they can be suspicious about the ulterior motives of the posting and infer that it is out of higher calculative motives.

H4. Influencer-product congruence will cause social media users to infer higher affective motive.

H5. Sponsorship disclosure will cause social media users to infer higher calculative motive.

Furthermore, the mediation effects of multiple motive inferences are proposed between the influencer advertising quality and social media users' response. It is plausible that, if congruence lets social media users infer that an influencer posted the product out of genuine affection, it will reduce advertising recognition and encourage a more favorable attitude toward the product.

H6. The effect of influencer-product congruence on (a) product attitude and (b) advertising recognition will be mediated by affective motive inference.

On the other hand, the sponsorship disclosure effects on the social media users' response will be mediated by calculative motive inference. In other words, the sponsorship disclosure will be a visual cue to evoke calculative motive inference from the influencer posting and cause higher advertising recognition and less positive product attitude. Hypothesized research model is described in Fig. 1.

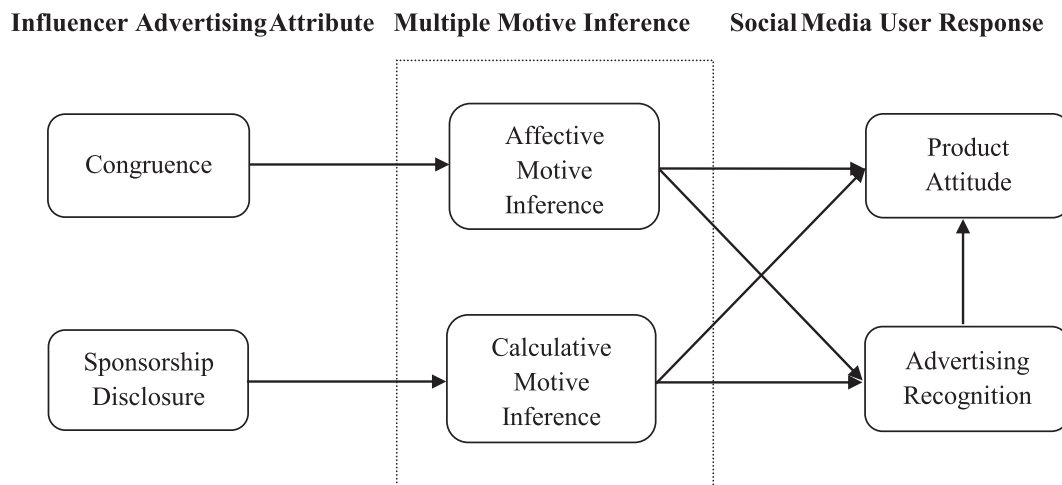


Fig. 1. Hypothesized research model * $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$, *** $p < .001$.

H7. The effect of sponsorship disclosure on (a) product attitude and (b) advertising recognition will be mediated by calculative motive inference.

3. Study 1

3.1. Study design

This study tested whether the influencer-product congruence and the sponsorship disclosure affect the inference of multiple motives of the influencer, advertising recognition, and product attitude. The mediation effects of affective and calculative motive inferences were also examined. A 2 influencer-product congruence (High vs. Low) $\times$ 2 sponsorship disclosure (Presence vs. Absence) between-subjects design was used to test the hypotheses. In the pretest, the influencer and the advertised product were selected to manipulate the influencer-product congruence. Sixty-six participants were recruited at Amazon's Mechanical Turk to develop four stimuli to be used in the main test. First, a female micro-level influencer with less than 50,000 followers was selected. Celebrity type influencers were excluded as their image and popularity can generate predispositions between participants and thus undermine the external validity. Additionally, influencers establish their identity based on the specific theme over the contents. In this study, an influencer specialized in a healthy lifestyle was selected to manipulate the congruence between the influencer identity and the endorsed product. The identity of the influencer was introduced to the participants with a few exemplary postings to show that she was famous for healthy lifestyle content. Furthermore, four types of beverage products (i.e. organic cleansing juice, protein shake, artificial powdered drink mix, high-calorie milk shake) were examined for the high and low congruence with the influencer. Organic cleansing juice and high-calorie milk shake revealed the highest and lowest congruence with the influencer promoting healthy lifestyle. Perceived congruence between the influencer and the organic cleanse juice was significantly higher than that between the influencer and the high-calorie milk shake ($t = 12.60$, $p < .000$). The sponsorship disclosure was manipulated by the presence and absence of the hashtag of “#Sponsored” as conducted in a previous study (Evans et al., 2017).

In the main test, participants were asked to respond to questions about the pattern of social media usage including usage frequency and preferred platforms. Those who indicated that they did not have an experience of using social media were excluded from entering the next step. Then, the definition of social media influencers was provided to help participants understand the concept and proceed to answer the questions. First, participants were asked to imagine a situation in which

they were exploring Instagram and found a few postings of an influencer. Then, a few exemplary postings of the selected influencer were presented to reveal her identity. In the next page, one of the four stimuli were randomly presented to the participants. Participants were asked to answer perceived congruence between the influencer and the product, affective motive inference, calculative motive inference, advertising recognition, and product attitude. The significant difference of perceived congruence was confirmed between high and low congruence conditions by t -test ($t = 12.23$, $p < .000$; $M_{\text{high}} = 5.29$, $M_{\text{low}} = 3.11$).

3.2. Instruments

The manipulation check of perceived congruence in the influencer posting was conducted by asking the degree to which respondents perceived the fit between the influencer and the brand posted. The instruments were adopted from Menon and Kahn (2003) including “How relevant is this influencer to the product?”, “how good is the match between the influencer and this product?” on a 7-point rating scale (1 = strongly disagree, 7 = strongly agree). Instruments for measuring affective and calculative motive inferences were adopted from Woisetschlager et al. (2017) and Allen and Meyer (1990). The respondents were asked to “evaluate the following statements about the relationship between the influencer and the brand” on a 7-point rating scale (1 = strongly disagree, 7 = strongly agree). The instruments for the affective motives included “The influencer feels emotionally attached to the brand” and “The brand has a great deal of meaning to the influencer.” The instruments for the calculative motives were “The major motive of the influencer's posting is self-interest” and “The influencer posts the brand to take advantage of it.” Advertising recognition was measured with instruments adopted from Boerman, van Reijmersdal, & Neijens (2012). Participants were asked to “indicate the extent in which you thought the Instagram post was advertising of the posted product” on a 7-point rating scale. Product attitude was measured with six items to the question of “How did you feel about the product in the Instagram post” on a 7-point semantic differential scale. The descriptions of the six items were; Desirable/not desirable, Pleasant/unpleasant, Likeable/not likeable, Good/bad (Silvera & Austad, 2004). Instrument items and the sources are summarized in Table 1.

A total of 185 U.S. consumers aged 18 or older were recruited from Amazon's Mechanical Turk platform. SPSS software was used for the analysis of data throughout the study. The age of the participants ranged from 20 to 72 ($M = 39.05$, $SD = 12.28$), who reported to use social media. The most popular social media platforms were Facebook ($n = 178$, 95.7%), YouTube ($n = 151$, 81.2%), Twitter ($n = 110$, 59.1%), and Instagram ($n = 104$, 55.9%) when participants indicated multiple platforms that they had used. The majority of the participants

Table 1
Instrument items.

Variables	Instruments	Source
Perceived Congruence	Manipulation Check Questions How relevant is this influencer to the product? How good is the match between the influencer and this product?	Menon and Kahn (2003)
Affective Motive Inference	The influencer feels emotionally attached to the product. The product has a great deal of meaning for influencer.	Woitschläger et al. (2017)
Calculative Motive Inference	The major motive of the influencer's posting is self-interest. The influencer posts the product in the posting to take advantage of it.	
Product Attitude	How did you feel about the product that was posted by the influencer? (Bipolar) Desirable/not desirable, Pleasant/unpleasant, Likeable/ not likeable, Good/bad	Silvera and Austad (2004)
Advertising Recognition	Please indicate the extent in which you thought the Instagram post was advertising of the product.	Boerman et al. (2012)

reported to use social media daily ($n = 158$, 82.3%), indicating a frequent use of social media. The manipulation check confirmed the two levels of influencer-product congruence ($t = 12.32$, $p < .01$). Inter-item reliability was confirmed for each multi-item scale: perceived congruence, calculative motive inference, affective motive inference, and product attitude, respectively ($\alpha = 0.95, 0.76, 0.91, 0.94$).

4. Results

4.1. Effects of congruence on advertising recognition and product attitude

A one-way MANOVA was conducted to test the effects of congruence on product attitude and advertising recognition. The congruence had a significant main effect on product attitude ($F(3, 181) = 4.18$, $p < .05$), but not on advertising recognition ($F(3, 181) = 2.20$, $p = .14$). Participants in the high congruence condition rated more positive product attitude than those who were in the low congruence condition ($M_{\text{high}} = 4.48$, $SD_{\text{high}} = 1.40$; $M_{\text{low}} = 4.05$, $SD_{\text{low}} = 1.43$). However, there was no significant difference in advertising recognition between high and low congruence conditions, ($M_{\text{high}} = 5.85$, $SD_{\text{high}} = 1.07$; $M_{\text{low}} = 5.60$, $SD_{\text{low}} = 1.23$). Thus, H1a was supported and H1b was not.

4.2. Effects of sponsorship disclosure on advertising recognition and product attitude

The effects of sponsorship disclosure on product attitude and advertising recognition were also tested using one-way MANOVA. Sponsorship disclosure had a significant main effect on advertising recognition ($F(3, 181) = 6.40$, $p < .05$) but not on product attitude ($F(3, 181) = 0.01$, $p = .91$). Participants who saw the posting with sponsorship message reported higher recognition of advertising than those who saw the posting without sponsorship message ($M_{\text{presence}} = 5.94$, $SD_{\text{presence}} = 1.02$; $M_{\text{absence}} = 5.51$, $SD_{\text{absence}} = 1.25$). However, product attitude did not differ between the presence and absence of the sponsorship message, ($M_{\text{presence}} = 4.27$, $SD_{\text{presence}} = 1.33$; $M_{\text{absence}} = 4.25$, $SD_{\text{absence}} = 1.52$). Therefore, H2a was rejected while H2b was supported. Furthermore, the effect of advertising recognition on product attitude was tested with linear regression analysis. Advertising recognition negatively affected product attitude ($\beta = -0.17$, $p < .05$), supporting H3.

4.3. Effects of congruence and sponsorship disclosure on multiple motive inference

The effects of congruence and sponsorship disclosure on multiple motive inferences were tested. Congruence had a significant effect on affective motive inference ($F(3, 181) = 9.13$, $p < .01$), supporting H4. Participants in the high congruence condition inferred higher affective motive from the posting ($M_{\text{high}} = 4.03$, $SD_{\text{high}} = 1.34$) than those who were in the low congruence condition ($M_{\text{low}} = 3.40$, $SD_{\text{low}} = 1.47$). In

addition, sponsorship significantly affected calculative motive inference ($F(3, 181) = 4.04$, $p < .05$), supporting H5. Participants who saw the posting with the sponsorship message inferred higher calculative motive behind the posting ($M_{\text{presence}} = 4.91$, $SD_{\text{presence}} = 1.03$) than those who saw the posting without the sponsorship message ($M_{\text{absence}} = 4.55$, $SD_{\text{absence}} = 1.35$).

4.4. Mediation effect of multiple motive inference

Correlation analysis was conducted to test the mediation effect of multiple motive inferences (See Table 2). According to the Pearson's correlation coefficient, the correlation between affective and calculative motive inferences was insignificant. The affective motive inference was significantly correlated with product attitude and advertising recognition, respectively. The correlation between calculative motive inference and advertising recognition was significant, but it was insignificant between calculative motive inference and product attitude.

The mediation effects of calculative and affective motive inferences were tested by bootstrapping analysis using PROCESS SPSS macro (Model 4, $n = 5000$ resamples; Hayes, 2015). First, the mediation effect of affective motive inferences was examined with congruence as an independent variable and product attitude as dependent variables. There was a significant mediation effect of affective motive inference (indirect effect: 0.1571, 95% CI = [0.0450, 0.2910]) between congruence and product attitude. Thus, H6a was supported. Furthermore, the mediation of motive inferences between congruence and advertising recognition was tested. Affective motive inference also revealed a significant mediation effect (indirect effect: 0.1377, 95% CI = [0.0384, 0.2759]). Therefore, H6b was supported. In sum, affective motive inference partially mediated the effect of congruence on product attitude and fully mediated the effect on advertising recognition.

Another analysis with sponsorship disclosure as an independent variable and calculative motive inference as a mediator was conducted on product attitude and advertising recognition. The mediation effect of calculative motive inference was significant (indirect effect: 0.0759, CI_{95%} = 0.0041 0.1740) between sponsorship disclosure and advertising recognition, supporting H7b. However, there was no significant mediation effect of calculative motive inferences on product attitude, rejecting H7a.

Table 2
Pearson's correlation coefficients of mediating and dependent variables.

Variables	Affective Motive	Calculative Motive	Product Attitude	Ad Recognition
Affective Motive	1			
Calculative Motive	-0.097	1		
Product Attitude	0.207**	-0.106	1	
Ad Recognition	-0.231**	0.232**	-0.192**	1

** $p < .01$

4.5. Discussion

Study 1 found that congruence between the influencer and the product enhanced product attitude by causing social media users to infer affective motive of the influencer for the product. Affective motive inference also mediated the effect of congruence on advertising recognition. The findings suggest that a high level of match between the influencer and the product affects product attitude and advertising recognition by attributing to the higher level of affective motive of the influencer. In addition, sponsorship message disclosure increased the advertising recognition by making social media users to infer calculative motive underlying the posting.

5. Study 2

5.1. Study design

Study 2 was conducted with a college student sample reflecting the largest age group of social media users (Smith & Anderson, 2018) to enhance the external validity. Recent statistics suggest that 90% of U.S. adults between the ages of 18–29 use social media (Statistica, 2019). In addition, the largest increase of using YouTube occurred among 59% of Generation Z (16–24) in 2018 (Chi, 2019). In this regard, college students well represent this largest portion of social media users. Two hundred and twenty-nine college students between 18 and 27 at a midwestern university in the U.S. were recruited in compensation with extra credits. The most frequently used social media was reported as Instagram ($n = 227$, 99.1%), YouTube ($n = 213$, 93.0%), Facebook ($n = 204$, 89.1.7%), Twitter ($n = 172$, 75.1%), and Pinterest ($n = 169$, 73.8%). The 93.9% ($n = 215$) of the participants used social media daily and 61.6% ($n = 141$) used it more than one hour a day.

Additionally, a set of stimuli was developed to examine 2 influencer-product congruence (High vs. Low) $\times$ 2 sponsorship disclosure (Presence vs. Absence) between-subjects design. In the pretest, forty-one participants were recruited at Amazon's Mechanical Turk to determine the products for high and low congruence conditions. In line with the study 1, the micro-level influencer with 11 K followers named “elyswellness” with health and wellness contents was selected. In the pretest, the influencer was introduced to the participants with exemplary postings showing her identity including healthy meals and drinks. Then, four different product images (e.g. smoothie blender, air fryer, hair dryer, and vacuum cleaner) were followed and the perceived congruence was asked respectively. Smoothie blender and air fryer were answered with the highest and lowest congruence with the influencer of health and wellness with significant difference ($t = 14.84$, $p < .000$). The sponsorship disclosure was manipulated with hashtag as in the Study 1.

In the main test, participants were given a scenario that they found an influencer “elyswellness” and saw a few exemplary postings. Then, one of the four stimuli were presented randomly to the participants and the questions on perceived congruence, multiple motive inferences, product attitude, and advertising recognition were followed. Perceived congruence was significantly different between high and low congruence conditions by t -test ($t = 34.22$, $p < .000$, $M_{\text{high}} = 5.40$, $M_{\text{low}} = 3.80$), confirming the manipulation of congruence.

6. Results

6.1. Effects of congruence on advertising recognition and product attitude

The effects of congruence on product attitude and advertising recognition was tested by a one-way MANOVA. The congruence significantly affected product attitude ($F(3, 225) = 11.16$, $p < .01$) and advertising recognition ($F(3, 225) = 2.89$, $p = .09$). High congruence condition between influencer and product resulted more positive product attitude in the low congruence condition ($M_{\text{high}} = 4.02$,

$SD_{\text{high}} = 1.17$; $M_{\text{high}} = 4.50$, $SD_{\text{low}} = 0.98$). There was no significant difference in advertising recognition between congruent and incongruent conditions ($M_{\text{high}} = 5.69$, $SD_{\text{high}} = 1.06$; $M_{\text{low}} = 5.94$, $SD_{\text{low}} = 1.14$). H1a was supported and H1b was rejected.

6.2. Effects of sponsorship disclosure on advertising recognition and product attitude

The effects of sponsorship disclosure were tested on product attitude and advertising recognition. Sponsorship disclosure significantly affected advertising recognition ($F(3, 225) = 6.95$, $p < .01$) but did not affect product attitude ($F(3, 225) = 2.17$, $p = .14$). Participants in the sponsorship message condition showed higher recognition of advertising than those who in the absence condition ($M_{\text{presence}} = 6.01$, $SD_{\text{presence}} = 1.06$; $M_{\text{absence}} = 5.63$, $SD_{\text{absence}} = 1.13$). However, the sponsorship message did not affect the product attitude ($M_{\text{presence}} = 4.37$, $SD_{\text{presence}} = 1.10$; $M_{\text{absence}} = 4.16$, $SD_{\text{absence}} = 1.10$). Therefore, H2b was supported but H2a was rejected. Moreover, advertising recognition significantly affected product attitude ($\beta = -0.20$, $p < .01$), supporting H3.

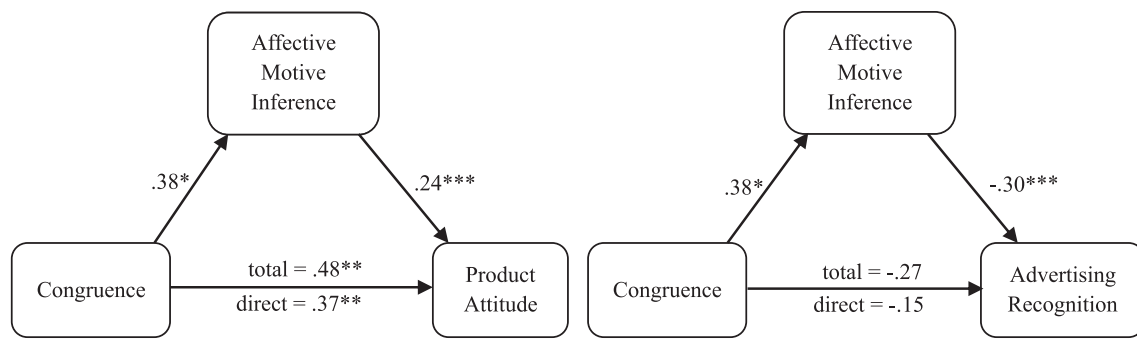
6.3. Effects of congruence and sponsorship disclosure on multiple motive inference

The effects of congruence and sponsorship disclosure were tested on multiple motive inferences. Congruence significantly affected affective motive inference ($F(3, 225) = 4.00$, $p < .05$), supporting H4. Participants who saw a congruent posting inferred higher affective motives from the posting ($M_{\text{high}} = 3.57$, $SD_{\text{high}} = 1.45$) than those who saw an incongruent posting ($M_{\text{low}} = 3.19$, $SD_{\text{low}} = 1.45$). In addition, sponsorship disclosure significantly affected calculative motive inference ($F(3, 225) = 10.56$, $p < .01$), supporting H5. The sponsorship hashtag resulted in higher calculative motive inference in the presence condition ($M_{\text{presence}} = 4.73$, $SD_{\text{presence}} = 1.08$) than in the absence condition ($M_{\text{absence}} = 4.22$, $SD_{\text{absence}} = 1.30$).

6.4. Mediation effect of multiple motive inference

The mediation analysis was conducted using PROCESS SPSS macro (Model 4, $n = 5000$ resamples; Hayes, 2015). First, a significant mediation effect of affective motives was found between congruence and product attitude (indirect effect: 0.0992, 95% CI = [0.0025, 0.2206]), supporting H6a. Affective motive inference also revealed an indirect mediation effect between congruence and advertising recognition (indirect effect: -0.1145 , 95% CI = [-0.2362 , -0.0052]), supporting H6b. The mediation of affective motive inference is presented in Fig. 2. Next, calculative motive inference mediated the effect of sponsorship disclosure on advertising recognition (indirect effect: 0.0647, 95% CI = [0.0023, 0.1602]), but did not on product attitude (indirect effect: -0.0609 , 95% CI = [-0.1505 , 0.076]). Therefore, H7a was rejected and H7b was supported. Hence, affective motive inference mediated the effect of congruence on product attitude and advertising recognition. The calculative motive inference mediated the effect of sponsorship disclosure on advertising recognition.

Then, a serial mediation analysis using PROCESS macro (Model 6, $n = 5000$ resamples; Hayes, 2015) was conducted between sponsorship disclosure on product attitude with mediation of calculative motive inference and advertising recognition (See Fig. 3 and Table 3). There was a serial mediation effect of calculative motive inference and advertising recognition between sponsorship disclosure on product attitude. Even though there was no direct effect of sponsorship disclosure on product attitude, there was an indirect effect mediated via calculative motive inference and advertising recognition (indirect effect: -0.0130 , 95% CI = [-0.0392 , -0.0003]).



* $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$, *** $p < .001$

Fig. 2. Mediation effects between congruence and product attitude * $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$, *** $p < .001$.

6.5. Moderated mediation of congruence

As advertising recognition mediated the effect of sponsorship disclosure, the moderating effect of congruence on the mediation was tested using PROCESS macro Model 14. The result provided a significant moderated mediation effect of congruence (indirect effect: 0.1022, 95% CI = [0.0036, 0.2309]) as presented in Fig. 4. In the high congruence condition, the effect of advertising recognition was insignificant on product attitude (estimate: -0.0538 , $p = .56$, 95% CI = [-0.2354 , 0.1278]), however was significant in the low congruence condition (estimate: -0.3213 , $p < .01$, 95% CI = [-0.4944 , -0.1483]). Thus, it can be concluded that congruence alters the mediation effect of advertising recognition between sponsorship disclosure and product attitude.

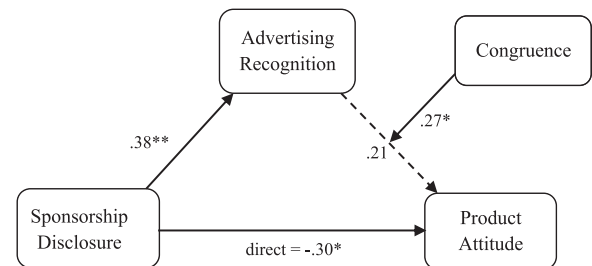
6.6. Discussion

The findings of Study 2 indicated that influencer-product congruence leads social media users to infer an affective motive of the influencer for the posting, further enhancing product attitude. The affective motive inference also fully mediated the effect of congruence on advertising recognition. In addition, sponsorship message caused social media users to infer a calculative motive of the influencer. Consequently, the calculative motive inference increased advertising recognition and decreased product attitude. Therefore, sponsorship disclosure indirectly affected product attitude in a negative direction. Moreover, congruence moderated the mediation effect of advertising

Table 3

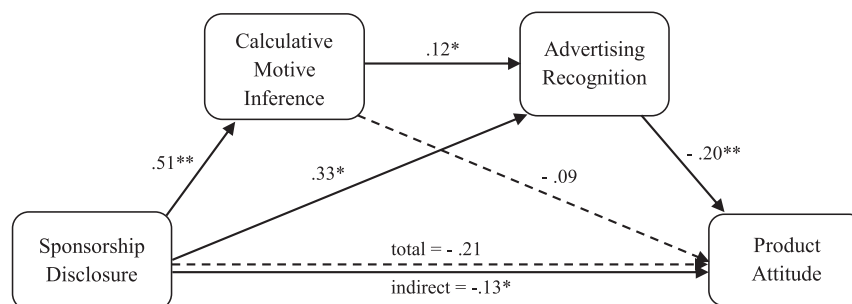
Indirect effects of calculative motive and advertising recognition.

Indirect Effects	Coefficients		Bootstrapping 95% CI	
	Estimate	SE	Lower	Upper
Total Indirect Effects	-0.1280	0.0548	-0.2465	-0.0298
Sponsor → Cal → Product Att	-0.0479	0.0385	-0.1299	0.0231
Sponsor → Ad Recog → Product Att	-0.0672	0.0388	-0.1549	-0.0045
Sponsor → Cal → Ad Recog → Product Att	-0.0130	0.0101	-0.0392	-0.0003



* $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$, *** $p < .001$

Fig. 4. Moderated mediation effect of congruence.



* $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$, *** $p < .001$

Fig. 3. The serial mediation effect between sponsorship disclosure and product attitude * $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$, *** $p < .001$.

recognition between sponsorship disclosure and product attitude. In the high congruence condition, advertising recognition did not exert an effect on product attitude.

7. General discussion

This study investigated social media users' response to influencer advertising based on the native advertising nature. Native advertising blurs the boundary between advertising and personal editorial contents (Conill, 2016) and can be processed differently from traditional advertising. It is important to understand which influencer advertising attributes are effective to induce positive responses from social media users. Specifically, the influencer-endorsed product congruence and the sponsorship message disclosure are demonstrated as being critical. Furthermore, a mediating process was examined based on the multiple inferences model. As influencer advertising includes both commercial and organic components, social media users can infer influencer's affective and calculative motives.

The first significant finding is that a product matched with the influencer can enhance product attitude, which is mediated by the affective motive inference. In other words, the influencer-product congruence can deliver a marketing message as a format of personal suggestions. The positive effect of the congruence is consistent with previous research on sponsorship marketing (Pappu & Cornwell, 2014; Woisetschlager et al., 2017). To successfully implement influencer advertising, marketers should design content that is congruent with the influencer's original postings and encourage the audience to engage in an affective motive state. Congruence also indirectly affected advertising recognition via the affective motive inference. A product that is matched to the influencer can create an assumption that the influencer may have genuine affection for the product and thus reduce advertising recognition.

Second, a sponsorship disclosure message causes social media users to recognize it as advertising, as concluded from a previous study (Evans et al., 2017). This study further demonstrated that the process is explained by the social media users' calculative motive inference. The hashtag "sponsored" is perceived as persuasion knowledge to infer that an influencer may receive compensatory rewards and has calculative motives for posting the product. Another significant finding is that sponsorship disclosure affects the product attitude in a serial mediation of calculative motive inference and advertising recognition. Building on the previous studies on persuasion knowledge (Boerman et al., 2015; Evans et al., 2017; Van Reijmersdal et al., 2016; Wojdowski & Evans, 2016) this study found that sponsorship disclosure's negative effect is caused by the inference on the calculative motive. The sponsorship message triggers the persuasion knowledge of consumers and make them infer ulterior motives behind the posting. It is followed by advertising recognition and the formulation of negative product attitude. Moreover, the moderation effect of congruence was examined on the mediation of advertising recognition between sponsorship message and product attitude. When advertising recognition mediated between sponsorship disclosure and product attitude, it exerted a negative impact on product attitude in the low congruence condition. However, the negative effect of advertising recognition on product attitude was not significant in the high congruence condition. This result implies that congruence can intervene the negative effect of advertising recognition when mediating between sponsorship disclosure and product attitude.

8. Conclusion and implication

The current research contributes to the literature on native advertising by examining the critical attributes of influencer advertising for

successful marketing communication. The significant effects of influencer-product congruence and sponsorship disclosure are demonstrated on product attitude and advertising recognition. Furthermore, the mediating process of inferring multiple motives is verified. As influencer advertising delivers a marketing message in personal content, both affective and calculative motives can be inferred by social media users simultaneously. Congruence is attributed to a higher affective motive of an influencer and results in higher product attitude and lower advertising recognition. On the other hand, sponsorship disclosure results in the inference of a greater calculative motive and enhanced advertising recognition, followed by a negative impact on product attitude.

Theoretically, the findings identify the processing mechanisms of crucial influencer advertising attributes in the native advertising context. Recent studies on native advertising were restrictive to examine either the positive effect of congruence or the negative effect of sponsorship disclosure (Breves et al., 2019; Evans et al., 2017; Evans et al., 2019; Evans et al., 2019; Schouten et al., 2019; Wojdowski et al., 2018). However, both positive and negative attributes for native advertising are processed by social media users, as examined in this study. The multiple inference model explained the mechanism with the processing of multiple alternative motives considering the situational attributes as well as prior persuasion knowledge (Reeder, 2009). Application of this model contributed to the understanding of how social media users perceive the influencer's personal editorial content while they also recognize a marketing intent.

This study also proposes practical implications to the influencer advertising industry. Brands and marketing agencies aim to employ influencer advertising; however, they struggle to use them effectively (Eyal, 2018b). This study emphasizes that we should understand how social media users receive influencer advertising in combination with a product. The fit between the influencer and the product can leverage the promotion effect by inducing affective motive inference of the influencer. Future research can explore additional positive attributes that can be attributed to affective motive inference and enhance marketing outcomes. Another practical implication is how to indicate sponsorship but avoid its negative effect on consumer attitude (Eyal, 2018a). Even though sponsorship disclosure negatively affects the product attitude, this study suggested a potential strategy to exploit the congruence effect. As advertising recognition's negative effect on product attitude did not exist in the high congruence condition, it will be crucial to enhance the congruence when disclosing the sponsorship message.

Native advertising on social media is gaining greater popularity and attracting more attention than traditional marketing communication. Specifically, "digital natives" who were born or brought up after mid 90 s are highly resistant to the traditional marketing messages (Lithium, 2016). Therefore, it will be more critical to understand the processing of native advertising. Future research can investigate how native advertising can be more receptive to specific consumer segments such as digital natives. In addition, the detailed aspects of an influencer can be investigated. Even though influencer advertising is emerging rapidly in the recent five years (Mediakix, 2018), the research perspectives were restrictive to native advertising and source credibility. In future research, influencer qualities that can be effectively used for a successful marketing activity can be investigated. For instance, the number of followers has been widely used to distinguish between micro, macro, and mega influencers (Fisher, 2018). However, there is increasing skepticism on the number of followers as a guideline to select an influencer (Eyal, 2018b; Ismail, 2018). Finding the effective qualities for employing influencers according to the target customer segment would be significant. For instance, the identities of influencers that made them popular can be explored for marketing implications.

Appendix A. Stimuli in study 1

Influencer introduction



564 likes
beth_norton 2 bananas, frozen mango, almond butter, @organicburst spirulina & almond milk topped with @elephant_food's 'brilliant berry boost' sprinkle - the perfect smoothie bowl 🍌💚



739 likes
beth_norton Eating the rainbow at @juicebabyuk with @catalina_rose 🌈🌈🌈



526 likes
beth_norton Fresh mint tea & candle scene at Dad's 🌿

Stimuli in four conditions (2 Congruence × 2 Sponsorship Message)



beth_norton With my Summer Cleanse juice # Sponsored



beth_norton With my Summer Cleanse juice



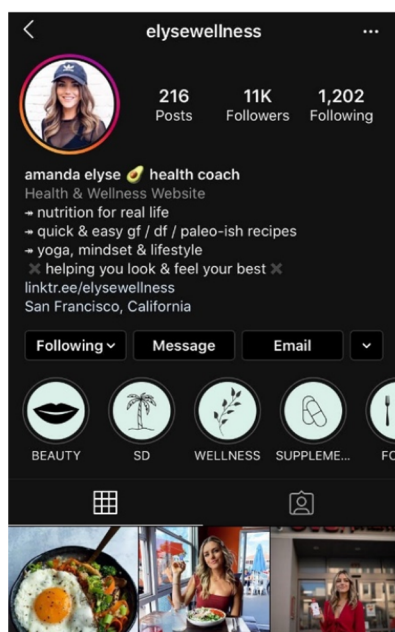
beth_norton With my milk shake of the Summer # Sponsored

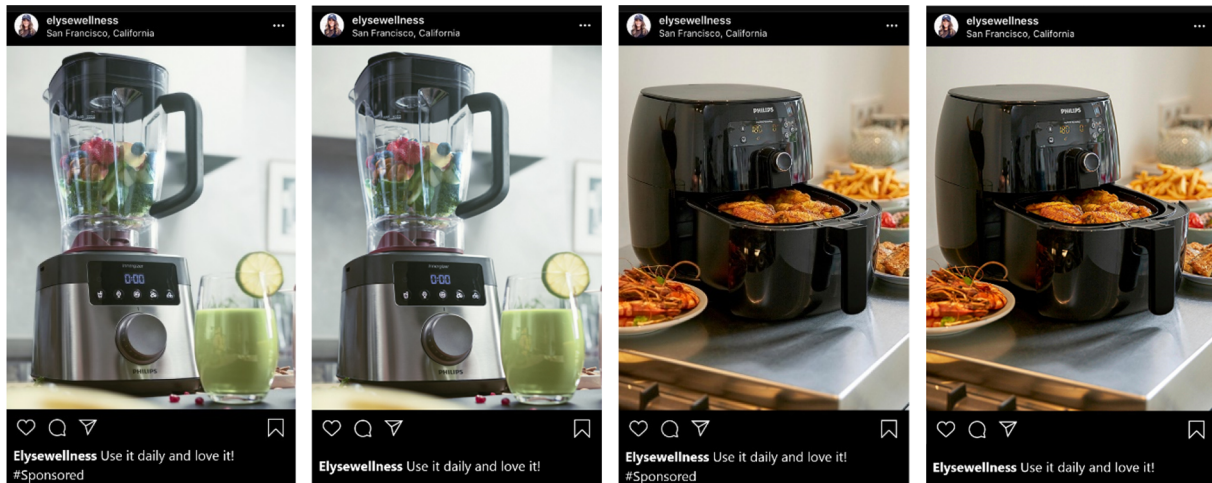


beth_norton With my milk shake of the Summer

Appendix B. Stimuli in study 2

Influencer introduction



Stimuli in four conditions (2 Congruence $\times$ 2 Sponsorship Message)

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